

POSITION THEORY

Think of any 7th chord as a TRIAD OVER A ROOT. Three positions — the foundation of smooth voice leading.

Any 7th chord = **Root in the left hand + a triad on top in the right hand.**

Example: Cmaj7 = C (left hand root) + an E minor triad (E-G-B) in the right hand.

That upper triad can sit in 3 different positions — and moving through those positions is how you voice-lead smoothly through any chord progression.

THREE POSITIONS OF CMAJ7

P1

LH ROOT 3 POSITION 5 TRIAD 7

C · E · G · B

RH: E-G-B (root position)

P2

LH 1ST INVERSION 5 TRIAD 7

C · G · B · E

RH: G-B-E (1st inv)

P3

LH 2ND INVERSION TRIAD 7

C · B · E · G

RH: B-E-G (2nd inv)

VOICE LEADING RULE THROUGH CYCLE 5

When chord roots move in ascending 4ths (Cycle 5), follow this pattern — it minimizes voice movement:

P3 → **P2** → **P1** → **P3** → **P2** → **P1** → ...

EXAMPLE — CMAJ7 → FMAJ7 (ASCENDING 4TH)

Cmaj7

POSITION 1

C · E · G · B

→

Fmaj7

POSITION 3

F · E · A · C

Notice: E stays put (common tone), G moves to A (half step), B moves to C (half step). Three notes move by step or stay — this is smooth voice leading. When roots move in 4ths, adjacent positions minimize voice movement automatically.